

The notional category of evidentiality

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Abstract This chapter is a focused discussion of analytical options proposed for evidentiality in recent formal literature as well as the empirical motivation behind those options. Much work has been devoted to the ontological relationship between evidentiality and (epistemic) modality, and the chapter pays special attention to the types of data that motivate the analysis of evidentials as intensional operators. My ultimate goal is to sharpen the dialectic. I re-examine the tests used in existing literature and provide new empirical diagnostics that probe the intensionality of evidential utterances. My hope is for the reader to emerge with a better understanding of evidentiality as a semantic category—and with many directions for future work.

Keywords cross-linguistic semantics, evidentiality, modality, not-at-issue content, semantic theory, semantics/pragmatics division of labor

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A wise man, therefore, proportions his belief to the evidence. [...] the evidence, derived from witnesses and human testimony, is founded on past experience, so it varies with the experience, and is regarded either as a proof or a probability.

—*Of Miracles*, David Hume

1 Introduction

One of the fundamental questions in formal semantics is how to model meaning. Semantic categories are instrumental in addressing it: they allow us to group linguistic expressions into natural classes and to make testable predictions about their behavior. Formal-semantic literature recognizes that modals may have a common semantic core despite morphosyntactic differences. Likewise, Bittner (2014) argues that temporality (semantic category) can receive a unified treatment in languages with or without tense (grammatical category). This chapter is on evidentiality, typically defined as linguistic encoding of the information source for an utterance (Chafe and Nichols 1986; de Haan 2013b). Inspired by Angelika Kratzer’s classic work on modality in natural language (1977; 1981; 1991; 2012), it aims at delineating the nature of evidentiality as a semantic, rather than morphosyntactic, category through a focused investigation of analytical options proposed for evidentials in recent formal literature and the empirical motivation behind those options. The emerging picture is that evidentials are best treated as providing reasons to believe and grounds for claims, and not just as expressions of information source.

Much work within the typological tradition has been devoted to the ontological relationship between evidentiality and (epistemic) modality (Aikhenvald 2004; van der Auwera and Plungian 1998; Bybee 1985; Palmer 1986): are they one category? different? distinct but overlapping ones? The formal-semantic literature raises related issues. According to the so-called modal view, evidentials can be assimilated to modal operators within Kratzerian semantics (Izvorski 1997). According to the so-called illocutionary view, evidentials in at least some languages instantiate a different category and should be analyzed as illocutionary force modifiers that directly interact with the structure of speech acts (Faller 2002; Murray 2014).¹ These views have been motivated by superficially different phenomena and have often been argued to track genuine semantic heterogeneity within evidentials. This chapter focuses specifically on the reasons to adopt or reject the modal view on evidentiality, which I will argue is complementary—rather than opposing—to the illocutionary one. My overarching goal is to examine how evidentials fit into the larger class of natural language phenomena dealing with knowledge and belief and whether they can be attributed the same core semantics as other modal expressions.

Current debates about the boundary between evidentiality and epistemic modality typically concentrate on (i) the (dis)similarities between specific evidentials and canonical epistemic modals (e.g., *might*, *must* and their counterparts in other languages), and on (ii) the merits of modelling evidentials within a version of Kratzerian possible-worlds semantics. However, it is important to recognize that different types of modals each have their unique properties (see 2.1

1. This view on evidentials echoes a long tradition that treats epistemic modals as categorically distinct from other modals, often argued to be illocutionary modifiers or comments on propositional content (Bybee et al. 1994; Halliday 1970; 2.1 EPISTEMIC MODALITY).

EPISTEMIC MODALITY, 2.2 PRIORITY MODALITY and 2.3 CIRCUMSTANTIAL AND ABILITY MODALS) and that Kratzer’s system isn’t always the best framework for some aspects of modal utterances, including their context update potential (1.4. DYNAMIC SEMANTICS FOR EPISTEMIC MODALITY), inference patterns (1.2 FROM MODAL LOGIC TO MODAL SEMANTICS), or graded nature (3.2 MODALITY, GRADABILITY AND PROBABILITY); see also 1.3 THE CONSTRUCTION OF MODAL DOMAINS. Furthermore, modality comes in various syntactic shapes and isn’t limited to modal auxiliaries (Arregui et al. 2017; 4.3 MODAL INDEFINITES, 4.4 MODALITY IN ADJECTIVES AND ADVERBS, 4.5 SUBLEXICAL MODALITY). Therefore, the fact that some evidentials may not behave like Kratzerian epistemic modals is not a reason to reject a modal account for such evidentials wholesale.

For the purposes of this chapter I will understand modality as making reference to intensional domains², in line with the large body of work on modality beyond grammatical modals, including conditionals (Kaufmann and Kaufmann 2015), predictive expressions (5.3 MODALITY AND THE FUTURE) and attitude predicates (6.3 MODALITY AND ATTITUDE VERBS). I argue that this view allows us to refine the dialectic surrounding the nature of evidentiality and to discern whether evidentials can be understood as belonging to the broad class of intensional operators. I discuss the range of tests that have been used to adjudicate between different theories in existing literature and bring to the fore novel empirical diagnostics that target intensionality. The emerging picture is that at least some evidentials are best understood as modals, just not necessarily Kratzerian epistemic modals. Evidentials on the whole bear many similarities to speech and attitude predicates, and the accessibility relations they lexicalize provide an instrumental way of grouping them into linguistically useful categories.

§2 provides empirical background on evidentials. §3 outlines the modal view on evidential meaning, highlighting points of contrast with other approaches. §4 discusses ways of diagnosing the modality of evidentials, including via evidential disjunctions, standard intensional effects such as presupposition blocking, and the interaction of evidentials with subjective expressions in their scope. §5 concludes. My hope is for the reader to come out with a better understanding of evidentiality at the semantics-pragmatics interface—and with many directions for future work.

2 Empirical properties of evidentials

Just like English obligatorily expresses temporal notions through the category of tense, languages like Tariana (Arawakan: Brazil; Aikhenvald 2003) obligatorily express how the speaker acquired the prejacent (e.g., via vision or other senses, through inference or assumption, or via hearsay). Based on many genetically and geographically unrelated languages that, like Tariana, have evidential paradigms, Aikhenvald (2004) establishes that evidentiality in those languages is an independent grammatical category that isn’t a species of modality. Aikhenvald’s explicit goal is to separate genuine evidentials (which express information source as their primary function) from other categories that may have an evidential flavor (dubbed ‘evidential strategies’). Furthermore, according to Aikhenvald (2004:4), “[l]inguistic evidentiality has nothing to do with [...] indicating one’s belief. All evidentiality does is supply the information source”.

This rigid view has been criticized from a functional-typological perspective. Even though many languages spoken in Europe express evidential notions through the tense-aspect or modal paradigms, it’s not obvious why they shouldn’t be included in the study of evidentiality on

2. Modality is usually understood as quantification over possible worlds. See 3.2 MODALITY, GRADABILITY AND PROBABILITY on alternatives to quantification and 1.2 FROM MODAL LOGIC TO MODAL SEMANTICS on alternatives to possible-worlds semantics for modals.

equal footing with Tariana (Diewald and Smirnova 2010), especially given that it's difficult to pinpoint the one primary function of multi-functional expressions (Boye 2010). Evidentiality is expressed via varied morphosyntactic means (de Haan 2013a). Extensive research within formal approaches to meaning demonstrates that these diverse expressions have much in common semantically (Murray 2017), despite the fact that some of them are 'only' evidential strategies in Aikhenvald's sense, e.g., aspectual morphology in Bulgarian (Izvorski 1997; Koev 2017; Simeonova 2020; Smirnova 2012), modal verbs in German (Ehrich 2001; Matthewson and Truckenbrodt 2017; Mortelmans 2000; Schenner 2008), high adverbials in English (Ernst 2009; Krawczyk 2012) or optional sentence-final particles in Japanese (Davis and Hara 2014; Hirayama 2020; Matsubara 2017; McCready and Ogata 2007).

The primary concern of this chapter is the core semantics of evidential expressions: what do they encode and what are the formal mechanisms behind it? While evidentials are typically defined as encoding only information source, they function as epistemic markers in larger discourses where they signal the speaker's authority or communicate shared knowledge (Bergqvist and Grzech 2023; Grzech and Bergqvist 2025; Mushin 2013). It is important to understand which aspects of their meaning are responsible for these patterns and whether pragmatic information is hard-wired. Below I discuss a range of properties associated with evidentials (see also extensive discussion in Murray 2017, 2021; Schenner 2010b): information source (§2.1), the speaker's attitude (§2.2), discourse status (§2.3), and perspectival anchoring (§2.4). For reasons of space, I do not discuss scope taking in detail (see Murray 2017:31-34). Evidentials always take wide scope with clause-mate negation (de Haan 1997; Korotkova 2020a),³ and vary with respect to other semantic operators, including conditionals (§2.3) and tense (Faller 2007); some of these properties can be explained by their syntactic position.

2.1. Source

The defining characteristic of evidentials is that they hard-wire information source for an utterance: how the speaker (in root declaratives, §2.4) acquired the prejacent. (1) lists information sources commonly found in the world's languages. Evidential paradigms, like most grammatical categories (Aikhenvald 2004; Speas 2004), typically distinguish between two and four values, while other evidential systems often show more fine-grained distinctions.⁴

(1) Taxonomy of information sources (based on Willett 1988)

DIRECT	INDIRECT	
	INFERENCE	HEARSAY
• visual • auditory • other sensory	• assumption • observable results	• secondhand • thirdhand • narrative

Three common evidential types are illustrated below: sensory *'dug* in Standard Tibetan (Tibeto-Burman: Tibetan Plateau, China; Garrett 2001; Kalsang et al. 2013), German inferential *wohl* (Germanic: Austria/Germany/Switzerland; Zimmerman 2004; Eckardt 2020),

3. Some evidentials have been argued to be positive polarity items (Dutch *schijnen*; Koring 2013), which explains their distribution. However, many evidentials can appear in questions and sometimes take narrow scope in conditionals, so not all evidentials can be treated as polarity-sensitive.

4. Some authors also include 'ego(phoric) evidentiality' (privileged knowledge about the prejacent). Part of the same morphological paradigm as evidentiality in many Tibeto-Burman languages, egophoricity is usually considered a separate category grammatically and conceptually (Floyd et al. 2018; Widmer 2019).

and Cheyenne reportative⁵ (Algonquian: Montana, USA; [Murray 2010, 2016](#)). For each of those expressions (and other expressions traditionally described as evidentials),⁶ the source requirement—the type of information source the evidential refers to—is entailed and cannot be cancelled.⁷

- (2) Tibetan *'dug*: speaker has evidence from senses (sight, smell, etc)

kha lag 'di bro ba chen po 'dug #yin na'i ngas bro ba bltas
 food this taste big POS EXIST.DIR but 1.ERG taste look.PST
 med

NEG.EXIST.EGO

'This food is tasty (I witnessed), #but I haven't tasted it.'

([Muñoz 2019:5](#))

- (3) German *wohl*: speaker infers based on body of information

Hein ist wohl auf See. #Ich sehe Hein dort auf der Cutty
 Hein be.3SG.PRES INFER at sea I see.1SG.PRES Hein there at DEF Cutty
 Sark, die gerade ausläuft.

Sark that straight sail.3SG.PRES

'Hein is at sea (I suppose). #I can see Hein right there sailing on the Cutty Sark.'

(adapted from [Eckardt 2020:10](#))

- (4) Cheyenne reportative: speaker has access to a report (heard, read, etc)

É-hó'táaheva-séstse Floyd #naa oha ná-sáa-néstó-he-Ø

3-win-REP.3SG Floyd and CNTR 1-NEG-hear-AGR-DIR

'Floyd won (I hear), #but I didn't hear that.'

([Murray 2010:55](#))

The choice between different evidentials in each individual language is constrained by various pragmatic factors beyond the source requirement ([Faller 2012](#); [Krawczyk 2012](#); [Murray 2010](#)). It is an open question whether 'information source' is a semantic primitive ([Krawczyk 2012](#)), or to what extent it is related to credence and reliability ([McCready 2015](#)). Take direct evidentiality. Typically associated with sensory information, for some expressions directness has been argued to encompass 'best possible grounds', the best type of evidence that can be available for a given proposition (Cuzco Quechua =*mi*, [Faller 2002](#); Southern Aymara =*wa*, [Martínez Vera 2024](#)). This includes evidence from senses, but also encyclopedic knowledge or reliable reports (cf. [Cariani 2022](#) on ideal grounding).

Likewise, indirect evidentiality raises many questions about the conceptual underpinnings of source restrictions. Thus, expressions called 'conjectural evidentials' often cover a broad spectrum (with the exclusion of eye-witness cases): they describe defeasible inferences from the speaker's body of knowledge, including assumptions, observations, speculations, and hearsay ([Eckardt 2020](#); [Faller 2002](#); [Murray 2010](#)). Importantly, such evidentials don't encode mere uncertainty: unlike probability operators (e.g., *likely*), conjectural evidentials are not licensed in

5. Cheyenne reportative doesn't have a citation form: its morphological realization depends on subject agreement.

6. With some expressions, inferences about the speaker's evidence are cancellable, e.g., Sanzhi Dargrwa perfect (Nakh-Daghestanian: Daghestan, Russia; [Forker 2018b](#)). I suggest that this property, rather than morphosyntactic realization, can be taken to demarcate the boundary between genuine evidentials vs. 'evidential strategies'.

7. Glosses: 1,3 number, ACC accusative, AGR agreement, CNTR contrastive, CONJ conjectural evidential, COP copula, DEF definite, DET determiner, DIR direct evidential, EGO egophoric, ERG ergative, EUPH euphonic, EXIST existential, FUT future, GEN genitive, ILLA illative, INAN inanimate, IND indirect evidential, INDEF indefinite, INF infinitive, INFER inferential evidential, NEG negation, NOM nominative, POS positive degree, PL plural, PRES present, PST past, PTCL discourse particle, PTCP participle, REP reportative evidential, SG singular, SUP superlative, TOP topic.

scenarios where the only evidence is purely statistical, though the speaker may rely on statistical information as part of their reasoning chain.⁸ Under this definition, English *might* can be described as a conjectural evidential (von Fintel and Gillies 2010; Matthewson 2015).

In addition to source restrictions, direction of reasoning and/or causality plays a role in the meaning of many evidential expressions (Davis and Hara 2014; Krawczyk 2012; Takubo 2009):

- Some expressions are bi-directional (the ASSUMED type in Krawczyk’s (2012) terminology): St’át’imcets *k’a* (Matthewson et al. 2007:205-206), English *presumably* (Krawczyk 2012:50-51), Sm’algyax *sn* (Brown 2025), or English *must*. They are compatible both with inferences from effect to explanation⁹ (e.g., from observable results to their cause) and with inferences based on general assumptions or eliminative reasoning.
- Many other expressions require the presence of an effect-to-explanation inference (the AP-PARENT type in Krawczyk’s (2012) terminology): St’át’imcets *an’* (Matthewson et al. 2007:205-206), Japanese *rashii* (McCready and Ogata 2007), Turkish indirect *mlş*, Central Alaskan Yup’ik *llini*, as well as English *evidently* and *apparently* (Krawczyk 2012).
- Conversely, predictive expressions are incompatible with effect-to-explanation inferences (English *will*, Winans 2016; Cumming and Winans 2021; Italian evidential future, Frana and Menéndez-Benito 2023).

Finally, several evidential expressions are sensitive to event structure, especially—but not exclusively—in those languages where they are part of the tense-aspect system, such as Tatar (see Bowler 2018 for discussion and extensive typological overview). Such expressions have been argued to encode the time/place of evidence acquisition relative to the speaker’s here and now, with the overlap between those eventualities leading to ‘direct evidence’ and non-overlap leading to ‘indirect evidence’ (Chung 2007; Bowler 2018; Faller 2004; Koev 2017; Nikolaeva 1999). Speas (2010); Kalsang et al. (2013) propose that all information source restrictions can be reduced to underlying event ontology; however, this claim is too strong. Many evidentials hard-wire both evidence source information and the relative ordering of the evidence acquisition time and the prejacent time (Hirayama and Matthewson 2022). Independent of prejacent tense, this parameter of evidential meaning is similar to the notion of temporal perspective for modals (Condoravdi 2002; 5.1 MODALITY AND TENSE).

Summing up, evidentials lexically encode information source for an utterance and may be additionally sensitive to other constraints.

2.2. Attitude

Evidentials systematically give rise to non-detachable inferences about the speaker’s attitude towards the prejacent, diagnosed by the impossibility of continuations that express disavowals and usually analyzed as entailments about belief/commitment (van Elswyk 2023; §3). All non-reportative evidentials require the speaker to consider the prejacent a live possibility (5), sometimes allowing weaker configurations $EV\phi \wedge EV\neg\phi$ (§4.2). Reportative evidentials often allow the speaker to void their belief (AnderBois 2014). Such evidentials are subject to cross-constructional variation with respect to disavowals (Korotkova 2026): (i) many encode nothing

8. Epistemologists argue that purely statistical information isn’t sufficient for knowledge or assertibility, nor (possibly) for justified belief (Buchak 2014; Hawthorne 2004). I flag it here as a tentative argument in favor of strengthening the connection between evidentiality in language and justification as a basis for knowledge.

9. Such inferences are often called ‘abductive’ (Douven 2021).

about the speaker’s stance and allow follow-ups of the form $\neg\phi$ (6),¹⁰ while (ii) some encode doxastic notions and are more constrained in the range of available follow-ups (7).

(5) German *wohl*

#Hein ist wohl auf See, und/aber er ist nicht auf See.
 Hein be.3SG.PRES INFER at sea and/but he be.3SG.PRES NEG at sea
 Intended: ‘Hein is at sea (I suppose), and/but actually he isn’t at sea.’ (Eckardt 2020:6)

(6) Cheyenne reportative

É-hó’táaheva-séestse Floyd naa oha e-sáa-hó’táaheva-he- $\emptyset$
 3-win-REP.3SG Floyd and CNTR 3-NEG-win-AGR-DIR
 ‘Floyd won (I hear), but he didn’t (I find).’ (Murray 2010:58)

(7) English *apparently*

Maria didn’t come to the party yesterday. Ana tells you that she was out of town. But you think that you might have seen her on the street.

Apparently, Maria was out of town ✓but I don’t think it’s true/#but I believe that this isn’t the case/#but I know she wasn’t. (Korotkova 2026)

Forker (2018a) notes that those evidentials that ban disavowals likely instantiate an overlap between evidentiality and epistemic modality. However, based on extensive research within formal semantics, this is not an arbitrary property of some evidentials, but a hallmark of evidentiality as a category. The fact that different types of evidentials systematically give rise to inferences about the speaker’s doxastic state demonstrates that they encode more than information source for the prejacent (pace Aikhenvald).

2.3. At-issueness

Evidential meaning is typically not-at-issue, backgrounded information that is not part of the main point of an utterance (Murray 2010, 2014, 2017). Unlike canonical presuppositions and like many parenthetical constructions, evidentials contribute discourse-new information and are felicitous when used discourse-initially. In line with research on not-at-issue content more broadly (see overview in Koev 2018), the literature on evidentiality offers different ways of construing and diagnosing evidential not-at-issueness. For example, it is often argued that the evidential restriction is not-at-issue because it is not directly challengeable in conversation (*No, you haven’t seen/heard/conjectured this* in an infelicitous reply to evidential utterances). However, the diagnostic applies only to some notions of at-issueness, and disagreement is independently infelicitous with first-person content, including evidentials (Korotkova 2016a,b). As discussed in detail in (Korotkova 2020a), the behavior of evidentials is best explained via the QUD notion of at-issueness according to which at-issue content is construed as QUD-relevant, and not-at-issue content as QUD-irrelevant (Beaver et al. 2017; Tonhauser et al. 2013, 2018). QUD at-issueness is diagnosed via answerhood, the ability to address explicit or implicit questions (Tonhauser 2012). Evidentials are naturally used when their prejacent answers the QUD (Context 1 in 8) and are usually infelicitous when the prejacent is QUD-irrelevant (Context 2 in 8).¹¹

10. The second clause in (6) features the morphologically unmarked direct evidential, which, as Murray (2016) notes, is difficult to adequately translate into English.

11. Evidentials have been argued to be QUD not-at-issue because they don’t answer questions about evidence (cf. Bary and Maier 2021; Faller 2019; Korotkova 2020a; Lee 2013; Martínez Vera 2024):

(8) ✓Context 1: Prejacent QUD-relevant, evidential signal QUD-irrelevant

You learn via the grapevine that your friends are organizing a surprise birthday party—for you. You hate surprises, and asked them more than once not to do that! When someone asks you why you are so upset, you say:

#Context 2: Prejacent QUD-irrelevant, evidential signal QUD-relevant

You learn via the grapevine that your friends are organizing a surprise birthday party—for you! You love surprises, and wish you hadn't heard about it. When someone asks you why you are so upset, you say:

German *sollen*

Meine Freunde sollen eine Party für mich organisieren. Echt schade.
my friend.PL REP.3PL.PRES INDEF party for me organize.INF total pity
'My friends are throwing a surprise party for me (I heard). Bummer.'

Evidentials are often compared to slifting parentheticals (*Voyager is coming home, I heard*) and are usually argued to be conventional markers of not-at-issue content (Faller 2019, 2023; Koev 2017; Martínez Vera 2024; Murray 2010, 2014, 2017).¹² Korotkova (2020a, 2026) argues instead that evidentials are conversationally not-at-issue (cf. Hunter 2016; Koev 2022 on parentheticals): the evidential restriction is QUD-irrelevant by default, but can become QUD-relevant in those discourses that warrant it.

Evidentials vary in the availability of a non-parenthetical, locally accommodated reading in the scope of semantic operators, such as speech and attitude reports (§2.4) or conditionals: some can take narrow scope in conditionals ($\approx [[\text{EV}\phi] \rightarrow \psi]$; St'át'imcets, Matthewson et al. 2007; Japanese, McCready and Ogata 2007), some always project ($\approx \text{EV}\phi \wedge [\phi \rightarrow \psi]$; Cuzco Quechua =*si*, Faller 2002; German *wohl*, Eckardt 2020), and some exhibit variability (Tagalog *daw*; Kierstead 2015).¹³ Importantly, it's a consensus that evidentials contribute parenthetical meaning at the matrix level and are most naturally used to provide grounds for some QUD-relevant information conveyed by the prejacent.

2.4. Perspective

Evidentials belong to the heterogeneous group of 'perspectival expressions' (Bylinina et al. 2015; Mitchell 1986; Zu 2018): they reflect the viewpoint of a sentient individual determined contextually or, in some cases, structurally. Some expressions allow exocentric readings whereby the perspectival center is a contextually-salient third party (Barlew 2016; Lasersohn 2005; Partee 1989), and this is a possible distinction between evidentials and epistemic modal auxiliaries. *Might* has been claimed to have exocentric readings (Egan et al. 2005; 2.1 EPIS-

- (i) A. How do you know that Jane is coming?
B. #Apparently, she is/✓I heard she is.

However, the prejacent of evidentials needs to contribute new information not settled by the immediate common ground (Korotkova 2026), so (i) may be infelicitous due to constraints on givenness, rather than at-issueness. (8) doesn't run into this problem.

12. Evidential meaning is not a Pottsian conventional implicature (Murray 2010, 2014, 2017): evidentials, unlike Pottsian supplements (e.g., appositives and *as*-parentheticals), can influence the speaker's commitment to at-issue content.

13. Some reportative evidentials can take wide scope in conditionals, yielding a speech report about the entire sentence $[\text{EV}[\phi \rightarrow \psi]]$ (Tagalog *daw*; Paraguayan Guaraní =*ndaje*, Tonhauser 2013). This is consistent with treating such reportatives semantically on a par with communicative predicates (13); the availability of this reading is likely enabled by syntax: all such evidentials are clitics and not part of the verbal spine.

TEMIC MODALITY). In contrast to that, evidentials are always speaker-oriented. (9) demonstrates that English *presumably* and German *wohl* cannot be anchored to a third party, even if this individual's evidence for the prejacent is of the right type (see also §4.1).¹⁴ Both expressions are felicitous in a similar scenario where they are speaker-oriented (10).¹⁵

(9) Context: Exocentric, third-party evidence

Ann is planning a surprise party for Bill, but Chris told Bill all about it. Now Bill and Chris are watching Ann set up the party without being discovered. Currently Ann is walking past Chris' apartment carrying a large supply of party hats. She sees a bus on which Bill frequently rides home, so she jumps into some nearby bushes to avoid being spotted. Bill and Chris are both watching from Chris's window and Chris asks Bill why Ann is hiding in the bushes. Bill says:

- a. ✓ I might be on that bus. (example and context from Egan et al. 2005)
- b. #I am presumably on that bus.
- c. German *wohl*
 #Ich bin wohl auf diesem Bus.
 I be.1SG.PRES INFER at this bus
 Intended: 'I am on this bus (Ann supposes)'.

(10) Context: Autocentric, own evidence

Ann wants to avoid Bill and, seeing a bus on which Bill frequently rides home and someone resembling him boarding it, jumps into the bushes. Chris, watching from the window, asks her sotto voce what's going on. Ann says:

- a. ✓ Presumably Bill is on that bus.
- b. German *wohl*
 ✓Bill ist wohl auf diesem Bus.
 Bill be.3SG.PRES INFER at this bus
 'Bill is on this bus (I suppose).'

In other environments, evidentials often undergo perspectival shift. In ordinary information-seeking questions, evidentials exhibit 'interrogative flip' (term from Tenny 2006): they request the addressee to respond based on evidence specified by the evidential and never admit genuine speaker-oriented readings.¹⁶ In speech and attitude reports, evidentials often admit more than one interpretation (Korotkova 2015; Schenner 2010b,a; Schwager 2010): (i) a concord reading: evidential vacuously matches the matrix verb (e.g., reportative evidentials under communicative predicates); (ii) a parenthetical reading: evidential evaluated relative to a higher world (like syntactically embedded speaker-oriented adverbials, e.g., fortunately); and (iii) a

14. *Presumably* belongs to what Ernst (2009) calls speaker-oriented adverbials, though Ernst doesn't discuss exocentric contexts.

15. Korotkova (2016b) makes a stronger claim and argues that evidentials require a 'de se' construal.

16. San Roque et al. (2017) incorrectly challenge the universality of the evidential interrogative flip. First, they don't control for clause type: some of their examples are *wh*-exclamatives (an environment where evidentials are not expected to shift, Bhadra forth.). Second, most apparent exceptions come from non-canonical questions, an umbrella term for constructions that deviate from ordinary information-seeking interrogatives (Eckardt et al. forth.). Korotkova (2016b:253-255) proposes that evidentials may remain speaker-oriented only in those questions that don't require the speaker's ignorance (e.g., quiz, rhetorical or biased questions); see (Brown 2025; Eckardt 2020; Faller 2023; Littell et al. 2010) on evidentials in conjectural questions, and (Bhadra 2020; Frana and Rawlins 2019, 2025) on the interaction of evidentials with question bias.

shifted, non-parenthetical reading: evidential evaluated relative to worlds introduced by the matrix verb (default interpretation of world-sensitive expressions in intensional environments, Farkas 1997; Percus 2000).¹⁷ Importantly, not all evidentials have each reading, and it is clear that the semantics of the predicate at least partially determines which evidentials can occur in its scope and with which interpretation. Furthermore, evidentials in some languages do not appear in complement clauses due to independent syntactic constraints on clausal complementation: evidentials are high on the clausal spine and some languages don't have a counterpart of *that*-complementation (Korotkova 2021). It is an open issue how perspective shift with evidentials should be analyzed and whether it can be assimilated to other grammatical or pragmatic mechanisms (Korotkova 2016b, 2020b; Murray 2021). I come back to the importance of a proper understanding of evidentials in root clauses in §4.1.

To recapitulate, evidentials—whether they are expressed via dedicated evidential paradigms, or other grammatical or lexical means—exhibit a range of cross-linguistic similarities that go beyond the semantic encoding of information source for an utterance. First, evidentials encode perspectival information and are anchored to the speaker in root declaratives. Second, all non-reportative evidentials and some reportative evidentials give rise to entailments about the speaker's attitude. Third, in typical discourses only the prejacent proposition contributes the main point of an utterance, with the evidential restriction conveying not-at-issue, peripheral information.

3 Theoretical accounts of evidentiality

Approaches to evidentiality within formal theories of meaning can be grouped into two families: **intensional** accounts and **extensional** accounts. Intensional accounts are usually referred to as the modal view on evidentiality. Extensional accounts include both (i) **illocutionary** approaches, wherein evidentials interact with the structure of speech acts, and (ii) **event-based** accounts, wherein evidential restrictions are a by-product of event ontology. This section outlines the core tenets of the modal view, highlighting important contrasts with other approaches.

Modal accounts of evidentiality treat evidentials as propositional operators within Kratzerian possible-worlds semantics for modality and parameterize the variation in the evidential domain using different force-flavor combinations, much like it's done for modal expressions at large, including attitude predicates (1.3 THE CONSTRUCTION OF MODAL DOMAINS—THE KRATZERIAN VIEW, 3.1 MODAL FORCE AND ITS REALIZATION ACROSS LANGUAGES, 6.3 MODALITY AND ATTITUDE VERBS). While some modals lexicalize neither force nor flavor (Steinert-Threlkeld et al. 2023), evidentials usually hard-wire at least flavor, which corresponds to the source restriction. The first modal approach to evidentiality was proposed by Pancheva (Izvorski 1997). She treats Bulgarian evidential perfect as a Kratzerian epistemic modal: a

17. The availability of different readings in intensional environments has been used as an argument for or against treating certain evidentials as modals (Matthewson et al. 2007; McCready and Ogata 2007; Sauerland and Schenner 2007): those evidentials that shift have been argued to be modal, while those that don't have been argued to be non-modal. First, all world-sensitive expressions—whether they are themselves extensional (adjective *deciduous*) or intensional (adjective *probable*)—are expected by default to refer to the local worlds when embedded under an attitude, unless a separate mechanism allows interpretation relative to a higher world (e.g., a 'de re' reading or projection). Second, this argument is framework-specific. If evidentials are analyzed as Kratzerian modals high on the clausal spine, they are indeed expected to shift (Hacquard 2010) and to not have parenthetical readings (Schenner 2010b; Schwager 2010). However, if evidentials are treated akin to speech and attitude predicates with a variable at-issue status (§3), their behavior in intensional environments is independent of whether or not they have a modal semantics.

universal quantifier over the most normal worlds selected by the stereotypical ordering source from the worlds compatible with what is known at the world of evaluation, with an indirect evidence presupposition. Similar analyses exist for other languages (Bhadra 2022; Brown 2025; Eckardt 2020; Faller 2011; Garrett 2001; Matsubara 2017; Matthewson et al. 2007; McCready and Ogata 2007; Peterson 2010; Smirnova 2012).

This section gives the precis of the modal view within Hintikkan semantics, using evidentials from §2.1 as exemplars. This schematic analysis preserves the spirit of existing modal accounts wherein evidentials are intensional quantifiers. At the same time, it doesn't run into framework-specific problems, some of which have been used as arguments against the modal view as a whole. First, it allows for explicit perspectival anchoring:¹⁸ because classic Kratzerian semantics doesn't specify whose information state is being tracked, it may overgenerate for evidentials, some of which are more constrained in root declaratives than canonical modals (§2.4, §4.1). Note that for clause-taking verbs, Hintikkan semantics reflects the syntax: their subject fills a thematic position of the predicate. The argument structure of evidentials is an open question that I do not discuss here (see Pancheva and Zubizarreta 2019; Simeonova 2020).

Second, this implementation allows more flexibility with respect to at-issueness and therefore has more purchase when it comes to the discourse dynamics of evidential utterances, including their behavior in conditionals (§2.3) and speech and attitude reports (§2.4). Most modal accounts implement the evidential restriction as a presupposition, however, this is not a defining property of the modal view. The system sketched below does not incorporate at-issueness explicitly. If one views evidentials as conventional triggers of not-at-issue content, they can be treated as speech and attitude predicates appearing in slifting parentheticals (*Voyager is coming home soon, I guess*), as in (Murray 2010, 2014, 2017).¹⁹ If one views evidentials as conversationally not-at-issue (Korotkova 2020a, 2026), they can be treated in parallel to 'discourse parentheticals' (*I guess Voyager is coming home soon*), constructions that have parenthetical meaning without parenthetical syntax (Hunter 2016; Simons 2007). In each case the key intuition is that evidentials may be attributed a modal semantics, just like speech and attitude predicates, and that this is conceptually independent of the at-issue status of the evidential restriction (cf. also §4.1).

3.1. Direct evidentials

Direct evidentials require the speaker to have evidence from senses (and, in some cases, 'best possible grounds'; §2.1), with similar restrictions lexicalized by English predicates *notice* and *observe*. Such evidentials are usually taken to encode full certainty (their compatibility with less-than-full certainty has not been tested, e.g., 'I am not fully certain whether ϕ '). Utterances with them are regarded as informationally stronger than unmodified assertions, which are omnivorous with respect to evidence type (Faller 2002; Martínez Vera 2024; Murray 2010). The lexical entry below correctly predicts that direct evidentials are felicitous when the prejacent is known/believed to be true (including with follow-ups like 'I know/believe ϕ ').

Perception alone does not guarantee belief. English *hear/see* have distinct epistemic profiles based on the complement type, and with bare infinitives they don't require belief (Barwise 1981; Higginbotham 1983; Moulton 2009; see also Müller 2020 on German). (11) below

18. For simplicity, the evidence holder in (11)–(13) is anchored to the speaker to account for root declaratives. These entries need to be modified to account for evidentials in other environments (§2.4).

19. Murray analyzes slifting parentheticals and Cheyenne evidentials on a par, arguing that they lack a modal operator. However, verbs used in slifts do have intensional semantics. Therefore, even though evidentials can/must be used parenthetically, it doesn't mean that they lack modal semantics. Instead, we might be dealing with a case of not-at-issue intensional operators, an analytical option not explored in the existing literature.

ensures the presence of belief by hard-wiring it, which correctly predicts that disavowals are contradictory (e.g., ‘I don’t believe ϕ ’ is not a felicitous continuation).²⁰

(11) Tibetan ‘*dug*

- a. Let $\text{SENS}(Sp, w)$ be the set of worlds compatible with the sensory evidence the speaker has at w and $\text{DOX}(Sp, w)$ the set of worlds compatible with the speaker’s beliefs at w .
- b. $\llbracket \text{'dug} \rrbracket^w = \lambda\phi \forall w' \in \text{SENS}(Sp, w)[\phi(w')] \wedge \forall v' \in \text{DOX}(Sp, w)[\phi(v')]$.
- c. $\llbracket (2) = \text{The food is tasty (I witnessed)} \rrbracket^w$
 $= \forall w' \in \text{SENS}(Sp, w)[\text{lx.FOOD}(x, w') \wedge \text{TASTY}(x, w')]$
 $\wedge \forall v \in \text{DOX}(Sp, w)[\text{lx.FOOD}(x, v) \wedge \text{TASTY}(x, v)]$.
- d. Disavowals banned:
 $\forall v \in \text{DOX}(Sp, w)[\phi(v)] \wedge \forall v' \in \text{DOX}(Sp, w)[\neg\phi(v')]$.

Epistemic modals like *must* have been argued to be incompatible with certainty and/or knowledge (see §3.2), and the (im)possibility to use an evidential when the prejacent is known to be true has been used as a diagnostic for epistemic modality (Faller 2002; Matthewson et al. 2007; Papafragou 2000). Thus, evidentials that are infelicitous when the prejacent is known to be true have been argued to have a modal semantics (St’át’imcets *k’a*, Matthewson et al. 2007). Conversely, several direct evidentials that are felicitous when the prejacent is known to be true have been argued to lack a modal semantics (Cuzco Quechua *=mi*, Faller 2002). Importantly, the felicity of an expression when the prejacent is known/believed to be true only tests whether that expression requires the speaker’s information state to be unsettled about the prejacent, but not whether this expression is an (epistemic) modal. For example, *hope* and *doubt* require unsettledness and are infelicitous with follow-ups indicating certainty (*I hope/doubt that it is raining on Ferenginar. #I know for sure that there is.*). On the other hand, attitude predicates that universally quantify over doxastic alternatives are felicitous precisely when the prejacent is believed to be true, albeit the corresponding follow-ups might be redundant (*Based on observations, I concluded that it was raining on Ferenginar. I am sure of it.*). Summing up, the fact some evidentials differ from *must* and *might* should not be used as an argument against treating those evidentials as epistemic modals.

3.2. Inference evidentials

Inference evidentials are often considered to be the meeting point of evidentiality and epistemic modality (van der Auwera and Plungian 1998) as in many ways such evidentials pattern like English *might* and *must*. For example, German *wohl* is most natural when the speaker draws a conclusion based on the body of information available to them: e.g., one can utter *Oma ist wohl einkaufen gegangen* ‘Granny went shopping (I suppose)’ if it’s Friday, her shopping day, and her shopping bag and purse are missing (Eckardt 2020:10); the lexical entry below specifies that ψ is some contextually available information based on which the inference is made. Inferential reasoning is also encoded by attitude predicates, e.g., English *ascertain* and *figure out*. (12) is a notational version of Eckardt’s (2020; 2025) semantics for *wohl* that treats it as a stereotypical weak necessity modal (cf. Izvorski 1997 on Bulgarian). On the one hand, it bans flat-out disavowals (5), and is also incompatible with knowledge that ϕ (Zimmerman

20. An alternative to hard-wiring belief with direct evidentials (11) will be to distinguish between perception of situations (non-epistemic) vs. of propositions (epistemic), as is done in the research on perception reports (Barwise 1981). In this case, the fact that sensory evidentials are treated as propositional operators in (11) will ensure belief.

2004; Eckardt 2020). On the other, it allows doubt: *Oma ist wohl einkaufen gegangen, aber ich bin mir nicht ganz sicher* ‘Granny went shopping (I suppose), but I’m not fully certain’ is non-contradictory. (12) predicts these facts by requiring that the speaker’s information state is unsettled.

(12) German *wohl*

- a. Let $\text{STEREO}(Sp, w)$ be the set of stereotypical worlds compatible with the speaker’s standards and expectations at w and $\text{DOX}(Sp, w)$ the set of worlds compatible with the speaker’s beliefs at w .
- b. $\llbracket \text{wohl} \rrbracket^w = \lambda\phi\exists\psi\forall w' \in \text{STEREO}(Sp, w)[\psi(w') \rightarrow \phi(w')]$
 $\wedge \exists v \in \text{DOX}(Sp, w)[\phi(v)] \wedge \exists v' \in \text{DOX}(Sp, w)[\neg\phi(v')]$.
- c. $\llbracket (3) = \text{Hein is at sea (I suppose)} \rrbracket^w$
 $= \exists\psi\forall w' \in \text{STEREO}(Sp, w)[\psi(w') \rightarrow \text{AT.SEA}(\text{HEIN}, w')]$
 $\wedge \exists v \in \text{DOX}(Sp, w)[\text{AT.SEA}(\text{HEIN}, v)] \wedge \exists v' \in \text{DOX}(Sp, w)[\neg\text{AT.SEA}(\text{HEIN}, v')]$.
- d. Disavowals banned:
 $\exists v \in \text{DOX}(Sp, w)[\phi(v)] \wedge \exists v' \in \text{DOX}(Sp, w)[\neg\phi(v')] \wedge \forall v'' \in \text{DOX}(Sp, w)[\neg\phi(v'')]$.

Inferential evidentials are often assumed to be weaker than unmodified assertions or assertions with direct evidentials (Faller 2002; Murray 2010; Smirnova 2012), the notion of weakness usually formalized as non-universal modal force (12) or as weak commitment to ϕ (§4.2). At the same time, there might be true necessity operators that encode indirectness/inference. Such operators are weaker only in that they are incompatible with sensory evidence (which often is considered the strongest possible evidence for a given claim).

English epistemic *must* is a good example of how different analyses can capture the same intuition. *Must*-claims have been argued to convey less certainty than unmodified assertions (Karttunen 1972), a fact attributed to its non-universal quantificational force ($\text{must}\phi \neq \Box\phi$; Kratzer 1991). von Stechow and Gillies (2010, 2021) propose instead that *must* is strong (= a universal quantifier), but semantically indirect, which explains perceived weakness without hard-wiring it. Other approaches to the same puzzle include a weak (=non-universal) and indirect *must* (Lassiter 2016; Roberts 2023); a weak (=non-universal) and non-evidential *must* (Goodhue 2017); and a strong (=universal) and non-evidential *must* (Mandelkern 2019). These debates, and especially the data they are based on, can be useful in adjudicating between different approaches to the strength of evidential expressions; see also Degen et al. (2019) for an experimental paradigm.

3.3. Reportative evidentials

Reportative evidentials, like speech reports at large, can be classified as information modals because they quantify over the pieces of information available to the speaker. Many such evidentials, including the Cheyenne reportative (6), don’t encode belief and allow the speaker to subsequently assert $\neg\phi$: the preadjacent *must* be true in the worlds compatible with the speech report, but not necessarily with the speaker’s belief worlds. (13) adapts Kaufmann and Kaufmann’s (2020) analysis of *according to* adverbials in English and is a notational variant of the standard Hintikka semantics for speech predicates (cf. Ehrlich (2001); Schenner (2008); Schwager (2010) on evidentials). It simply states that the speaker is familiar with the content of some report, but does not specify how the speaker came by this information, as many reportatives don’t constrain the report’s type (the speaker could have read it, heard it from someone, etc). Reportatives that are more constrained can be modelled in a more specific way, in the same

vein one would model the differences in the mode of information acquisition between *read* vs. *overhear* (cf. [Grimshaw 2015](#) on SAY-by-means). The subject of communicative verbs is often the report’s author (*announce*), but evidentials are more similar to those whose subject is the recipient (*overhear*). Some reportatives allow/require overt specification of the original author (‘quotative evidentials’; [Aikhenvald 2004:177-178](#)), but it has not been tested whether they differ semantically from source-unspecified reportatives.

(13) Cheyenne reportative

- a. Let $\text{CONTENT}(x, w)$ be the propositional content associated with the source x in w .
- b. $\llbracket \text{Cheyenne reportative} \rrbracket^w = \lambda\phi\exists x\forall w' \in \text{CONTENT}(x, w)[\phi(w')]$
 $\wedge \text{FAMILIAR}(Sp, \text{CONTENT}(x, w), w)$.
- c. $\llbracket (4) = \text{Floyd won (I hear)} \rrbracket^w = \exists x\forall w' \in \text{CONTENT}(x, w)[\text{WIN}(\text{FLOYD}, w')]$
 $\wedge \text{FAMILIAR}(Sp, \text{CONTENT}(x, w), w)$.
- d. Disavowals allowed:
 $\lambda\phi\exists x\forall w' \in \text{CONTENT}(x, w)[\phi(w')] \wedge \text{FAMILIAR}(Sp, \text{CONTENT}(x, w), w)$
 $\wedge \forall v' \in \text{DOX}(Sp, w)[\neg\phi(v')]$.

The possibility of disavowals has often been used as an argument against the epistemic modal analysis of evidentials ([Faller 2002, 2019; Smirnova 2012](#)), however, it only applies to specific implementations of the modal view. The impossibility to assert $\neg\phi$ after $\text{EV}\phi$ without a contradiction may indeed diagnose the presence of a certain quantification domain (e.g., a realistic modal base; [Kratzer 2012](#)), but not the existence of a modal operator generally. (13) allows disavowals because the quantification domain of the modal needn’t include the actual world or the speaker’s belief worlds. Some reportative evidentials ban flat-out disavowals (7), much like communicative predicates *be right* and *confirm*. These differences within speech reports (with or without evidentials) in the availability of disavowals can be parameterized by adding doxastic restrictions on top of the general semantics in (13) (as in [Korotkova 2026](#)).

3.4. Discussion

The modal schema in (11)–(13) reduces the variation in evidentiality to force-flavor combinations and models it using Hintikkan machinery, typically applied to clause-taking predicates. The goal of this treatment is to highlight rarely noticed parallels between evidentials on the one hand and speech and attitude reports on the other.²¹ Many clause-taking predicates lexicalize information source restrictions. For example, *notice* and *observe* require perception, *figure out* and *realize* require inference (of any kind), while *learn* and *find out* require the presence of an inference from-effect-to-explanation and are compatible with a wide range of evidential contexts, including hearsay ([Korotkova and Anand 2024](#)). Likewise, many doxastic predicates differ in force (6.3 MODALITY AND ATTITUDE VERBS): some encode full belief (*know*, *infer*), while some encode weaker notions (*doubt*, *suspect*; see especially [Močnik 2025](#)). Furthermore, the differences in disavowals between reportative vs. non-reportative evidentials mirror the differences between communicative vs. doxastic predicates ([Korotkova 2026](#)). Speech reports allow the subject to reject the prejacent (*✓Starfleet announced/claimed/declared that Voyager was coming home, but I knew it wasn’t true.*). Attitude reports, on the other hand, require their subject to consider the prejacent a live possibility (*#I believed/concluded/guessed that Voyager*

21. This is not to say that evidentials don’t differ from clause-taking predicates. However, just like with modal auxiliaries vs. attitude predicates, the question is whether these differences can be derived from syntax while maintaining a unified semantics (6.3 MODALITY AND ATTITUDE VERBS).

was coming home, but I knew it wasn't true). Summing up, modal accounts offer a powerful apparatus that parameterizes the behavior of evidential expressions using the tools often applied to modal expressions more generally and underscore that distinctions found in the evidential domain closely resemble the patterns observed with speech and attitude reports. Below I briefly discuss two main competitors to the modal view: the illocutionary and the event-based accounts.

Illocutionary accounts Illocutionary accounts of evidentiality treat evidentials as force modifiers that semantically interact with the structure of speech acts (see 7.1 SPEECH ACTS AND MODALITY), and underscore the importance of linguistic data in philosophy of language debates. Under this view, evidentials tap into mechanisms responsible for grounding and justification, and directly determine the speaker's (in root declaratives) commitment to the prejacent, e.g., by manipulating the quality threshold for assertions (Davis et al. 2007). The first account of this type was proposed for Cuzco Quechua by Faller (2002), who argues that evidentials operate at the level of sincerity conditions for a speech act. Another prominent account is due to Murray (2010, 2014, 2017), who treats evidentials as hedges (Benton and van Elswyk 2020), which may weaken the speaker's commitment to at-issue content. Direct evidentials propose an update with ϕ (like assertions), inference evidentials propose an update with $\Box/\Diamond\phi$ (like shifting parentheticals), and reportative evidentials, which may require no commitment (6), propose a trivial update with $\phi \vee \neg\phi$ (7.1 SPEECH ACTS AND MODALITY). The cornerstone of most such accounts is that evidentials are associated with construction-specific discourse updates (Faller 2019, 2023; Martínez Vera 2024; Northrup 2014) and are therefore taken to be categorically different from modals, which necessarily have an intensional operator in their semantics and thus modify commitment indirectly.²² Initial research suggested that all semantic variation within evidentiality stems from the distinction between modal vs. illocutionary evidentials (see Korotkova 2016b, 2021 for arguments against this view), for example, evidentials that take the widest scope with respect to semantic operators have been argued to be illocutionary. However, scope taking with modals is subject to a variety of constraints (6.1 MODALS, NEGATION, CONCORD, AND POLARITY), and epistemic modals often have the widest scope (Hacquard 2011), so this is not an argument against the modal view. As Murray (2021) emphasizes, the illocutionary view on evidential meaning is not incompatible with an intensional semantics for evidentials and merely doesn't require it.

Event-based accounts Purely event-based accounts treat evidentials as extensional operators whose only function is to encode a relation between eventualities within the same world (see overview in Bowler 2018). For example, Faller (2004) argues that Cuzco Quechua *-sqa* encodes spatio-temporal distance between the prejacent eventuality and the deictic center, leading to 'indirectness'. An important prediction of such accounts is the impossibility of weak commitment, diagnosed via uncertainty follow-ups: even indirect evidentials are predicted to give rise to full commitment by virtue of being used in assertions (which commit the speaker to the prejacent; Marsili 2024; Pagin and Marsili 2025). To the best of my knowledge, this prediction has not been tested for evidentials argued to be event-based. Absent such data, we can use the behavior of English *by now* adverbials as a proxy. Such adverbials have a purely temporal semantics (the onset of the resulting state described by the base predicate precedes the time of the adverbial) that leads to indirectness effects (Altshuler and Michaelis 2020). As Altshuler and

22. With the exception of (Krifka 2019), where both epistemic modals and evidentials are treated as commitment modifiers.

Michaelis’ account correctly predicts, these adverbials don’t affect commitment (14), unlike hedges conveyed via parentheticals or non-universal modals (15). In future research, the data as in (14) may help determine whether a purely deictic semantics is sufficient to explain the behavior of putatively event-based evidential expressions (cf. also [Hirayama and Matthewson 2022](#)).

(14) #Voyager came home by now, but I’m not completely sure.

- (15) a. ✓Voyager came home already, I think/suspect, but I am not completely sure.
 b. ✓Maybe/possibly Voyager came home already, but I am not completely sure.

The choice between modal vs. non-modal views on evidentiality is often portrayed as a dichotomy: evidentials in a given language should be analyzed either as (Kratzerian) modals or as a species of another semantic category. I offer a different conceptualization. Commitment-related or temporal ingredients are compatible with modal semantics. On the one hand, different modal expressions can affect the speaker’s commitment to the prejacent (as in (15b)). On the other hand, there is a deep connection between temporality and modality (5.1 MODALITY AND TENSE), and some evidentials have been analyzed as relative tenses with a doxastic component ([Lee 2013](#); [Johnson 2022](#); [Smirnova 2012](#)). The defining characteristic of modal accounts is the presence of an intensional operator. To this end, in order to refute the modal view we need to show that evidential expressions are not intensional, an issue I turn to in the next section.

4 Probing for modality

Some evidentials have been argued to be modal, while some other evidentials have been argued to be non-modal. Various tests have been proposed to probe for this distinction. This section sharpens the dialectic concerning the modal view on evidentiality, inspired by research on modal future (especially [Cariani 2021](#); [Klecha 2014](#)). Predictive expressions have been analyzed as purely temporal operators within tense logic (5.3 MODALITY AND THE FUTURE) as well as purely discourse-based commitment weakeners ([Frana and Menéndez-Benito 2023](#)). Across languages, predictive expressions doesn’t pattern like epistemic modals (e.g., conjunctions with epistemics, or scope with negation). Nevertheless, they induce intensional effects and are therefore best understood as modals. I advocate a similar approach to at least some evidentials that can be shown to require an intensional operator in their semantics, though they may not pattern like *might/must*: §4.1 discusses the non-diagnostic of (dis)agreement; §4.2 disentangles existential force from weak commitment; §4.3 explores standard intensional effects with evidentials; §4.4 proposes two new tests based on the interaction of evidentials with subjective predicates.

4.1. Modality and (dis)agreement

This section reviews an argument from analogy made in the literature on evidentiality to draw a line between modal vs. non-modal evidentials. Here is how it goes. If *might* exhibits a certain pattern, then those evidentials that exhibit a similar pattern are semantically similar to *might* and should be analyzed as epistemic modals. Conversely, if some evidentials do not exhibit the same pattern, they must not be analyzed as epistemic modals. The pattern in question is the possibility to (dis)agree with a modal claim containing English epistemic modal auxiliaries

(Khoo 2015; Knobe and Yalcin 2014). As I show below, while the analogy works (evidentials that behave like *might* must have something in common with it), the similarity is due not to the presence of the modal operator. Instead, it is rooted in different bodies of knowledge different expressions refer to. Data from (dis)agreement therefore should not be taken to diagnose the modality of evidentials, as they simply point to a distinction within modals as a class.

Consider (16) for St'át'imcets inferential *k'a* (Salish: British Columbia, Canada) and (17) for English *might*, based on (von Fintel and Gillies 2008:83) and the game of Mastermind:

(16) St'át'imcets *k'a*

Imagine a game where someone places some different colored pegs behind a screen and the other person has to guess the colors and the order after getting some clues. After some rounds where I give my son some hints about the solution, he says:

wá7 k'a i tseqwts'qw-a

be INFER DET.PL red-EXIST

'There are some reds (there is inferential evidence for that)'

Possible responses include:

a. wenácw; wá7 k'a

true be INFER

'That's true. There is inferential evidence [that there are some reds].'

b. wenácw; wá7

true be

'That's true. There are [some reds].' (adapted from Matthewson et al. 2007:223)

(17) There might be some reds.

a. That's right, there might be [some reds].

b. That's right, there are [some reds].

St'át'imcets inferential *k'a* (16) mirrors the behavior of English *might* (17). In response to a *k'a*-claim, one can respond using *k'a* (16a) and with a plain assertion (16b). Matthewson et al. (2007) and later literature interpret the data in the following way. Epistemic *might* has a modal operator, $\Diamond$, in its semantics. Additionally, *might*-claims make both the modalized proposition $\Diamond\phi$ (17a) and the unmodalized prejacent ϕ (17b) available for propositional anaphora with *That's right/true*. The expectation is that one can agree with $\Diamond\phi$ only if it is at-issue (cf. Amaral et al. 2007 on the role of such data in determining at-issueness). The literature concludes that only modal evidentials are expected to allow the response in (16a), while evidentials that don't allow the pattern similar to (16a) and (17a) lack a modal operator in their semantics (Faller 2019, 2023; Murray 2014, 2021).²³

Presence of a modal operator The data in (16)-(17) should not be taken to diagnose the absence of a modal operator as there are modal expressions that do not pattern like *might*. First-person attitude reports have intensional semantics, however, they block certain responses due to first-person authority: (18b) is odd not because it is weird to openly assess someone else's mental process (the other person knows better). Anaphora of a different type (that doesn't involve agreement) is fine (18c).

23. The literature on epistemic modality uses data from both agreement and disagreement, however, disagreement with evidentials is often blocked for independent reasons (Korotkova 2016a,b).

(18) I assume/guess/suspect that there are two reds.

- a. ✓ That's right, there are.
- b. # That's right, you do.
- c. ✓ That is surprising that you do.

At-issueness The data in (16) show that St'át'imcets *k'a* allows both the *k'a*-claim and the prejacent to be targeted by propositional anaphora *That's true*. However, the fact that some evidentials don't allow such responses does not mean that they lack a modal operator. Anaphoric potential is linked to at-issueness only in some theories (the so-called proposal at-issueness, Koev 2018). As discussed in §2.3, evidentials are best understood using the QUD notion of at-issueness, diagnosed via the ability to answer questions. Snider (2017) demonstrates that anaphoric potential is neither necessary nor sufficient for QUD at-issueness. Importantly, not all modals make the modalized claim available for anaphora, so the data in (16) shouldn't be taken as an argument that those evidentials that allow only the prejacent to be targeted by anaphora (allowing only the response in (16b)) lack a modal component in their semantics altogether.

The knower The literature on epistemic modality uses Mastermind scenarios like (17) to demonstrate that English epistemic modals may not have an individual argument and are instead sensitive to an information state parameter, because even in root declaratives they don't have to be anchored to the speaker's body of evidence and may refer to public knowledge (DeRose 1991) or to a third party's evidence (2.1 EPISTEMIC MODALITY). The fact that certain expressions cannot refer to public/third-party knowledge and must be anchored to the speaker in root declaratives is compatible with those expressions having a modal semantics, just the one different from *might*. For example, Tancredi (2007) proposes that epistemic modals may have objective, knowledge-based readings vs. subjective, belief-based readings. Mastermind scenarios test the availability of the objective reading, but not modality.

Consider (19).²⁴ Responses with *might*, *possibly* or *for all we know* are acceptable (19a). On the other hand, English *presumably* (19c) and German *wohl* (19d), unlike St'át'imcets *k'a*, are infelicitous (unless B means them to refer to their own information state) and pattern like first-person attitude reports (19b):

(19) *A and B are playing Mastermind. A is the codebreaker and B is the codemaker, knowing exactly how many red pegs there are (two). B is keeping track of what A has figured out but doesn't want to give away the solution just yet.*

A says: There are two reds.

B replies:

- a. ✓ There might be. / Possibly there are. / For all we know, there are.
- b. #I assume/guess/suspect that there are.
- c. #Presumably there are.

24. Note that these examples are different from purely exocentric cases in (9).

d. German *wohl*

#Es gibt wohl zwei rote Stifte.
 it give.3SG.PRES INFER two red peg.PL
 Intended: ‘There are two red pegs (I suppose).’

Evidentials have been assumed to be always speaker-oriented in root declaratives (§2.4). It has not been tested systematically whether they allow readings tracking mutual evidence (*≈for all we know*). If, as the data suggest, there is a split between evidentials that are acceptable in Mastermind scenarios (St’át’imcets *k’a* and *an’*) and those that are not (English *presumably*; German *wohl*; Italian evidential future, [Frana and Menéndez-Benito 2023:144](#)), this is a genuine case of semantic variation in the evidential domain: (i) some evidentials pattern like *might* and can track mutual evidence (*≈for all we know*), and (ii) some evidentials pattern like first-person attitude reports and track individual evidence. The behavior of *might*-claims can be accounted for in a number of ways ([Rudin 2025](#)), which may or may not be applicable to evidentials. Importantly, the fact that some evidentials are not licensed in scenarios requiring them to ascribe evidence to a third party, or to make a claim based on shared information, does not show that these evidentials do not have a modal semantics; it only shows that these evidentials differ from *might* and can be modals of a different kind (like first-person attitude reports).

Finally, Mastermind cases can only be tested with a subset of evidentials. Given the guessing nature of the game, it excludes sensory and reportative evidentials.²⁵ Additionally, not all inferential evidentials are compatible with the type of reasoning the game requires, as some of them are not licensed in speculative contexts that often lack the effect-to-explanation component (§2.1). Summing up, while the data in (16)–(19) offer valuable insights into the semantics of evidentials, they do not adjudicate between intensional vs. extensional theories of evidential meaning.

4.2. Existential force vs. weak commitment

For many evidentials, it is often difficult to empirically tease apart the predictions of accounts assigning them (near-)universal modal force vs. strong discourse commitment. But existential force is easier to detect. The hallmark of existential modals is the felicity of $\Diamond\phi \wedge \Diamond\neg\phi$.²⁶ Consider the behavior of Cuzco Quechua *=chá* (Quechuan: Peru), typically analyzed as an all-purpose conjectural evidential:

(20) Cuzco Quechua *=chá*

Inés-chá llali-rqa-n. Pilar-taq-chá llalli-rqa-n.
 Inés-CONJ win-PST-3 Pilar-CNTR-CONJ win-PST-3
 ‘Possibly Inés won. And possibly Pilar won.’

Comment: non-contradictory even if the two women participated in the same race, and only one can be the winner. ([Faller 2002:187](#))

[Faller \(2002\)](#) analyzes *=chá* as a force modifier whose prejacent is $\Diamond\phi$. [Faller \(2023\)](#) removes the modal part and treats *=chá* only as a commitment weakener (cf. [Murray \(2014\)](#) on the Cheyenne conjectural). However, weak commitment is commitment: the speaker puts forth ϕ , signalling that their grounds for asserting might not be as waterproof as with a regular

25. Reportative evidentials are usually infelicitous if the original author is one of the interlocutors (similarly to obviation effects; [Schwager 2010](#)). So if the codemaker gives hints by saying something, the codebreaker can’t convey this by using a reportative evidential (*≈There are two reds, you said*).

26. Thus, German *wohl* is not an existential modal—the following is contradictory: #*Ines hat wohl gewonnen. Und Pilar hat wohl gewonnen.* (*≈Ines won (I suppose). And Pilar won (I suppose).*)

assertion. (20) is then supposed to convey that the speaker weakly commits to ϕ and also to $\neg\phi$, weakly asserting both propositions. Without comments about possible belief revision, this sounds contradictory, just like the corresponding statement with two slifting parentheticals (assuming there can only be one winner):

(21) #Inés won (I suppose). And Pilar won (I suppose).

On the other hand, (20) is straightforward under a modal analysis. Existential epistemic modals (e.g., *might*) minimally encode that the speaker’s information state is decided on the non-impossibility that ϕ (the speaker can’t exclude ϕ) and can be strengthened pragmatically (Rudin 2019). (20), and its English translation, simply signal that the speaker excludes neither ϕ nor $\neg\phi$; it is a face-saving way of communicating ‘I don’t know’ (Eckardt 2025:432-433). I conclude that Cuzco Quechua =chá has an existential operator in its semantics (in line with Faller 2002, 2011). It is a separate issue whether its discourse effects can be derived from its core semantics (as Rudin argues for *might*) or whether they should be encoded directly. The availability of the pattern in (20) supports the modal account of evidentials that give rise to it and therefore offers a tangible diagnostic for the intensionality of some evidentials.

4.3. Intensional domains

Drawing on the literature on intensional environments, this section considers three diagnostics that identify the presence of a modal operator: modal subordination, presupposition blocking and contradictions allowed due to a ‘de re’ interpretation.

Modal subordination Modal Subordination (MS) is a phenomenon whereby anaphora and other forms of presupposition satisfaction are often blocked in intensional environments unless in the scope of another intensional operator (Roberts 1996, 2021). It is triggered, e.g., by modal auxiliaries, conditionals or disjunction. Several evidentials have been argued to be modal based on this diagnostic (Faller 2017; McCready and Ogata 2007; Lee 2013; Smirnova 2012). (22) demonstrates for Japanese *mitai* (isolate: Japan).

(22) Japanese *mitai*

We are in a cabin in the woods, with no window, listening to a howling noise outside. We think that we are hearing a wolf, or wolves; but in fact the north wind is just strong tonight.

- a. [ookami-ga]_i kita mitai da
wolf-NOM came INFER COP.PRES
‘[A wolf/Some wolves]_i has/have come (it seems).’
- b. [yatsu(ra)-wa]_i totemo onaka-o sukaseteiru *(mitai da)
it(they)-TOP very stomach-ACC emptied INFER COP.PRES
‘[It/they]_i is/are very hungry *(it seems).’ (McCready and Ogata 2007:166)

This diagnostic is particularly useful for inferential evidentials that closely resemble epistemic modals in their discourse effects. MS is expected to be triggered by (i) intensional evidentials (such as Japanese *mitai*), but not by (ii) extensional evidentials that weaken commitment or encode temporality. Thus, *by now* adverbials do not give rise to MS (23).

(23) ✓By Friday, Magda submitted [a paper]_i. It_i was on modality.

However it's difficult to test with direct evidentials: MS is tied to commitment and isn't obligatory. Therefore, we may not see it with direct evidentials not because they aren't modal, but because they require commitment. The same consideration applies to reportative evidentials: e.g., Cuzco Quechua =*si* has been claimed to be used almost veridically without overt disavowals (Faller 2019), which may be responsible for the absence of MS effects.

Presupposition blocking Speech and attitude reports can block the presuppositions of their prejacent from projecting to the matrix level because they create a space for local accommodation (Heim 1992 and much later work). Korotkova (2026) shows that several reportative evidentials pattern like communicative predicates and function as intervening operators that may block their prejacent's presuppositions. (24) demonstrates for German *sollen* and the soft trigger *nicht mehr* 'anymore'; a corresponding sentence without the evidential is infelicitous. This test is only applicable to those reportative evidentials that don't require belief.

(24) German *sollen*

You read in a reputable newspaper that Switzerland stopped drilling in the Arctic.

Die Schweiz soll in der Arktis nicht mehr bohren. Aber hä? Die
 DEF Sw. REP.3SG.PRES in DEF Arctic NEG more drill.INF but PTCL DEF
 Schweiz hat doch gar nicht in der Arktis gebohrt.
 Sw have.3SG.PRES PTCL PTCL NEG in DEF arctic drill.PTCP
 'Switzerland supposedly won't drill in the Arctic anymore. But wait a minute,
 Switzerland hasn't drilled there at all.' (Korotkova 2026)

'De re', 'de dicto' and contradictions Intensional environments give rise to 'de re'/'de dicto' ambiguities and are known to ameliorate contradictions because they allow different parts of the prejacent to be evaluated with respect to different worlds: expressions in the main predicate position must be read 'de dicto' while expressions outside of main predicate position can be read 'de re' or 'de dicto' (Anand and Korotkova 2022; Farkas 1997; Keshet 2010; Musan 1997; Schwarz 2012). Korotkova (2026) shows that several reportative evidentials pattern like communicative predicates in this respect and allow prejacent that otherwise sound contradictory (this test only applies to those reportative evidentials that don't require belief). Corresponding sentences without evidentials are infelicitous, unless with a special quotative intonation (which itself signals the presence of an intensional environment; cf. Anand and Korotkova 2022:623). (25) illustrates for Turkish *mİş* (Turkic: Turkey).²⁷

(25) Turkish *mİş*

You read an article about a very dangerous disease, claimed to be caused by a fungus, while in fact you know that it is a virus.

Dünya-nın en ölümcül virüs-ü virüs değil-miş.
 world-GEN SUP deadly virus-ACC virus NEG.COP-IND
 ≈ 'I hear that the world's deadliest virus is not a virus'. (Korotkova 2026)

27. Turkish *mİş* is an indirect evidential compatible with abductive inferences and hearsay (Johanson 2000; Krawczyk 2012; Meriçli 2016; Slobin and Akşu 1982). For some speakers, all uses of *mİş*, including as a reportative evidential, require a belief that ϕ . At the same time, for many younger speakers it allows disavowals (Şener 2011) and therefore licenses presupposition blocking and intensional contradictions (see discussion in Korotkova 2026).

Faller (2002:256) notes the following contrast between reportative $=si$ (analyzed as a force modifier) and $-sqa$ (analyzed as a spatio-temporal extensional operator, Faller 2004): $=si$ allows a ‘de dicto’ interpretation in its scope (26), while $-sqa$ doesn’t.

(26) Cuzco Quechua $=si$

- a. Estados Unidos-pa rey-ni-n-si Peru-man chayamu-nqa.
States United-GEN king-EUPH-3-REP Peru-ILLA arrive-3FUT
‘The king of the United States will come to Peru (I hear).’
- b. Ichaqa mana chiqaq-chu. Estados Unidos-pi-qa mana-n rey kan-chu.
But not true-NEG. States United-LOC-TOP not-DIR king be-NEG
‘But this is not true. There is no king in the United States.’

(adapted from Faller 2002:256)

Faller does not explain the contrast, however, her analysis predicts that $=si$ and $-sqa$ would pattern together and block ‘de dicto’. Furthermore, based on the English translation the DP in question, *Estados Unidos-pa rey* ‘king of the United States’, can trigger the existence presupposition, in which case we observe a difference in presupposition blocking between $=si$ (blocking licensed) and $-sqa$ (blocking not licensed), also not predicted by Faller’s analysis in which the semantics of $=si$ has no intervening operator that would allow local accommodation. I propose an alternative take: like a range of reportatives in other languages, $=si$ is an intensional operator (cf. Faller 2011), while $=sqa$ is truly extensional.²⁸

4.4. Interaction with subjective predicates

Subjective expressions, which describe matters of opinion (*delicious*, *lugubrious*), can have an exocentric reading in root declaratives (Lasersohn 2005). *The defense was not scary* can be uttered autocentrically (by the defending student) or exocentrically (by the proud supervisor). Many approaches postulate a special implicit argument j , the judge, in the semantic denotation of such predicates making them semantically distinct from ‘objective predicates’ (*deciduous*, *left-handed*). Reportative evidentials—like speech reports at large—block an autocentric reading of subjective expressions in their scope. Because (27) can only mean that the judge is not the speaker, Murray (2017, 2021) argues that the evidence holder is distinct from the judge and that the denotation of the Cheyenne reportative must include a judge shifter.

(27) Cheyenne reportative

É-pèehéva’é-nèse
3-good-REP.INAN.SG
‘It is good (I hear).’

(Murray 2017:46-47)

The data as in (27) are important for the understanding of the semantics of evidentials, as they help us diagnose intensionality. As discussed in detail by Anand and Korotkova (2022), if judges are included in the semantics of subjective predicates at all, they must correlate with worlds of evaluation ($\llbracket \text{good} \rrbracket^{\langle j, w \rangle} = \lambda x. \text{GOOD}(x, \langle j, w \rangle)$). If an expression shifts the judge, it has to shift the world of evaluation as well, and theories that divorce judges from worlds make incorrect predictions for subjective expressions in intensional environments. Theories that don’t postulate implicit arguments for subjective predicates don’t face those problems ($\llbracket \text{good} \rrbracket^w = \lambda x. \text{GOOD}(x, w)$). Therefore, the fact that the Cheyenne reportative shifts the judge

28. (26) features the future marker $-nqa$, however, even if it is an intensional operator (like many predictive expressions), such modals do not license ‘de re’/‘de dicto’ ambiguities or presupposition blocking, so the effect in (26) is due to the presence of $=si$.

of a subjective predicate in its scope indicates that it is not just a force modifier (pace Murray) but also an intensional operator (that minimally shifts the index, as in (13)—and possibly the judges, if they are included in the denotation of subjective predicates).

The interaction of evidentials with subjective predicates provides another diagnostic for intensionality. A subset of subjective predicates trigger an acquaintance inference (28a; term from Ninan 2014): the requirement that the judge has some experience with the object in question (the nature of experience varies; Anand and Korotkova 2018; Cariani 2022; Muñoz 2019; Soria-Ruiz 2024). A range of expressions can block this inference, including *must*-modals (28b) and inferential evidentials (28c), but not direct evidentials (2).

- (28) a. The tea was delicious, #but I never tasted it.
 b. The tea must have been delicious, ✓but I never tasted it.
 c. German *wohl* (based on Korotkova and Anand 2021:521)
The tea is freshly brewed and the color is just right.
 Der Tee ist wohl lecker, ich habe ihn aber noch nicht
 DEF tea be.3SG.PRES CONJ delicious I have.1SG.PRES but it yet NEG
 probiert.
 try.PTCP
 ‘The tea is delicious (I suppose) but I haven’t tried it yet.’

The acquaintance inference can be blocked only by intensional expressions. Some authors argue that intensionality is enough (Klecha 2014; Ninan 2020), while some others argue that blocking arises only with those intensional expressions whose evidential restrictions semantically interact with the the acquaintance inference (Anand and Korotkova 2018; Muñoz 2019; Korotkova and Anand 2021). Crucially, the pattern in (28) strongly speaks in favor of an intensional analysis of acquaintance-blocking expressions.²⁹ Depending on the specific analysis, direct evidentials, which do not block the acquaintance inference, can be treated as intensional (just not indirect; (11)) or as extensional.

This section offers several concrete diagnostics that support the inclusion of a modal operator in the denotation of evidential expressions: (i) the possibility of statements of the form $EV\phi \wedge EV\neg\phi$, which diagnose existential modal force (e.g., Cuzco Quechua =*chá*); (ii) the possibility of modal subordination, presupposition blocking and contradictory prejacent, which diagnose intensional environments (e.g., Cuzco Quechua =*si*, German *sollen*, Turkish *mls*); (iii) judge-shifting and acquaintance-blocking with subjective expressions, which is difficult to explain on a non-modal analysis (e.g., Cheyenne reportative, German *wohl*). These tests have not been applied consistently across languages. However, preliminary data suggest that even evidentials in Cuzco Quechua and Cheyenne, whose behavior has been used to argue against the modal view, come out as having an intensional semantics.

Note that these diagnostics are limited and only apply to evidentials that don’t require full certainty/endorsement.³⁰ Direct evidentials are difficult. They have been argued to give rise to

29. There are also non-linguistic accounts of acquaintance that don’t take intensionality or evidentiality into account (the so-called ‘epistemic view’, Felka 2025; Ninan 2014), but they make incorrect empirical predictions (Anand and Korotkova 2018; Soria-Ruiz 2024; Ninan 2020).

30. One can argue that modal displacement always goes hand in hand with the lack of complete commitment. It is a separate question whether all such cases can be analyzed in purely non-modal terms (e.g., by making modal subordination or presupposition blocking dependent exclusively on discourse commitments, but not the presence of a particular semantic environment). An exploration of this option is beyond the scope of this paper.

full certainty/commitment because they ban disavowals, however, their compatibility with less-than-full-certainty follow-ups has not been tested. Given that what we know, such evidentials can be treated as universal quantifiers with full belief, as force modifiers with full commitment, or as spatio-temporal modifiers with commitment supplied by assertion. Some authors have argued that direct evidentials must be attributed non-modal semantics because other evidentials from the same paradigm are not modal, however, this argument is morphosyntactic rather than semantic. One way to move forward will be to gauge the behavior of direct evidentials against some known properties of modals: (i) necessity modals don't distribute over disjunction ($\Box[\phi \vee \psi] \not\models \Box\phi \vee \Box\psi$), (ii) epistemic modals outscope strong quantifiers (**every>must/might*; von Fintel and Iatridou 2003), (iii) epistemic necessity modals are incompatible with preferential doxastics (**must* under *hope*; Anand and Hacquard 2013). I leave exploring those possibilities for future research.

5 Outlook

The defining feature of the modal view on evidential meaning is the presence of an intensional operator in the semantic denotation of evidential expressions, with force-flavor combinations determining their specific linguistic profile. This does not exclude illocutionary effects or temporal constraints also included into such modal meanings, contrary to the accounts that treat those views as alternatives. For example, some evidentials encode temporal constraints, which motivates the inclusion of the evidence acquisition time in their semantics (Hirayama and Matthewson 2022; Johnson 2022; Lee 2013). On the other hand, some evidentials have non-trivial common-ground management properties (Grzech 2020; Martínez Vera 2024), which suggests that they directly make reference to discourse structure (much like discourse particles). For some evidentials, we can show that they are intensional (§4). On present knowledge, there might also exist purely extensional, non-modal evidentials. The debates on the proper semantics of evidentials in many ways resemble, on the one hand, the debates on epistemic modals as propositional operators vs. comments on propositional content, and, on the other hand, the debates on predictive expressions as temporal vs. modal operators. Current approaches to evidentiality have often been motivated by superficially different data and therefore focus on distinct features of evidential expressions. The overarching goals of this chapter is to elucidate conceptual issues surrounding evidential meaning, focusing on arguments for or against treating evidentials as a type of modal expression and providing empirical tools that diagnose evidential intensionality.

Extensional evidentials that don't affect commitment (cf. (14)) can be treated as event operators. Extensional evidentials that affect commitment can be assimilated to parenthetical expressions that encode illocutionary effects semantically (cf. Koev 2022), as Murray argues for Cheyenne. However, if evidentials are shown to be intensional, it is worth checking how much mileage we can get out of their basic semantics. Canonical epistemic modals modulate commitment to the prejacent, which may be analyzed via construction-specific discourse updates for epistemic claims or via deriving commitment indirectly from epistemic probabilities (Rudin 2019). Similar analytical options exist for evidentials, and deciding between them taps into larger questions about the relationship between discourse and grammar present in the literature on question bias, imperatives and clause typing at large: can the update potential of any given utterance be derived from its core semantics in conjunction with a single update mechanism and general pragmatic reasoning? This chapter focuses specifically on the semantic question. It shows that evidentials can be analyzed within the same framework as speech and attitude reports, further classified into semantically useful subtypes based on the accessibility relations

they lexicalize (e.g., inferential or reportative evidentials), much like it's traditionally done for clause-taking predicates (e.g., the distinctive profile of communicative (Anand et al. 2017) or intention predicates (Grano 2017) is determined by their flavor). My hope is that a consistent application of the diagnostics discussed here will help adjudicate between different theories of evidential meaning, thus carving a way towards a better understanding of evidentiality as a semantic category.

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